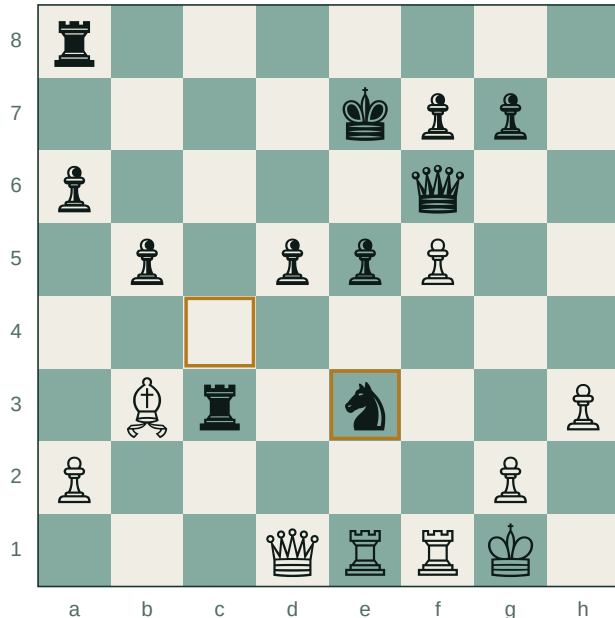


Capture the defender: White, move 29

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 28...Ne3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

29. Rxe3 Rxe3 30. Qxd5 Rd8 31. Qc5+

29.Rxe3 The rook captures the knight on e3. Recorded reply: **29...Rxe3**.

30.Qxd5 The queen captures the pawn on d5. Recorded reply: **30...Rd8**.

31.Qc5+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. From c5 it attacks king on e7 and rook on e3.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 24 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by -1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -1: the balance goes from -2 to -3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on e7. Geometrically undefended: rook on a8 and rook on c3. Check for tactical protection.